Precise answers / Don’t round up

Helping students refine a response

Use precise-answer routines when a partly correct response is being accepted as complete. Help the student improve the answer rather than silently replacing it with your own explanation.

How to do it well

1 Listen to the actual answer. Judge what the student said against the intended knowledge rather than what you think they meant.

2 Name the useful start. Recognise the accurate element and identify the missing or imprecise feature.

3 Prompt a revision. Use a clue, key term, criterion or short rehearsal to make improvement achievable.

4 Return for the full answer. Ask the pupil to articulate the complete explanation, then involve listeners in restating or applying it.

5 Check a fresh case. Use a related question when needed to establish that the refined reasoning can be used beyond the rehearsed wording.

What this sounds like

“You have the main idea. Say it again using ‘concentration’ and explain which way the particles move. I will give you a moment to prepare.”

Classroom example. A pupil’s answer contains a correct idea but omits the condition that makes it valid. The teacher recognises the accurate start, prompts the missing feature and returns to the pupil for the full explanation. A new example follows. The teacher does not silently supply the condition and treat the original response as complete.

Top tips that make the technique work

Identify the missing feature. Decide whether the issue is vocabulary, evidence, a condition or the relationship between ideas.

Use an attainable prompt. Point to the needed feature without providing the whole answer when the pupil has the knowledge.

Return to the same student. They should articulate the completed response after the support.

Use “Say it again, better”. Ask for a fuller, more precise version and specify what must improve.

Keep the tone warm. Accuracy and a supportive response can coexist; do not turn refinement into public humiliation.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Require the pupil to complete or refine the response.	Rounding up a partial answer as fully correct.
Make the criterion for precision explicit.	Supplying the explanation and crediting the pupil with it.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton — Don’t round up